

1943–1946

COMPETITIVE COUTURE

Commenting on the Paris Spring Collections of 1945, *American Vogue* noted “a very slight tendency towards the longer skirts, Balenciaga, Lelong, and Rochas showing them a bit more below the knee”. The supremacy of French couture had been challenged during World War II, with Norman Hartnell claiming that London fashion designers had given “the home product a stability and elegance which hitherto was possessed by Paris alone”. After the Liberation of Paris in August 1944, the fight for the place at the top of the fashion tree and the search for a new silhouette began. French designers did not waste time and soon dispatched their latest outfits to cities in Europe and the US. In London, the 1946 Britain Can Make It exhibition showcased 5,000 goods destined for export, including ready-to-wear and couture clothing, which were seen by almost 1.5 million visitors. In October 1945, *Life* magazine declared that “New York custom dresses are high fashion”. But could the US and Britain resist the lure of Paris chic?

UTILITY CLOTHING

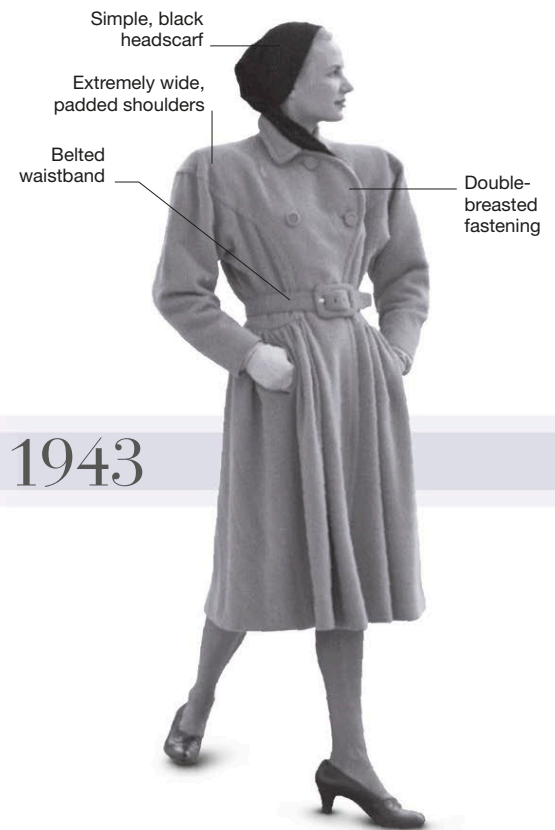


1944 advertisement

Austerity Regulations, which had simplified the female silhouette, were lifted in England in 1946, but clothes rationing continued for another three years. Utility clothing had ensured that good-quality garments were available to all at modest and regulated prices, and was not phased out until 1952. This 1944 advertisement for the utility range of the London ready-to-wear company Jaeger shows the wide shoulders and short skirts typical of the war years; the narrowing waists and the slight flare of the skirt on the right are pointers to the future.



Spring fashions Despite being part of the Spring Utility collection, this dress shows a more balanced and feminine silhouette than earlier in the decade. The slight gathering into the skirt increases emphasis on the waist and hips.



1943

American style This soft wool coat by ready-to-wear designer Monte-Sano strikes a bold silhouette. The width of fabric over the shoulder pads is gathered into deep folds at the waist and forms an extremely full skirt.



1946

V-necks Despite cloth shortages, very wide shoulders became fashionable towards the end of the war. These two outfits are variations on a theme: V-necks, narrow waists, skirts with pleats on either side of a flat front, and dark accessories.